



Triumph sealed: Deepti Sharma fittingly sealed India's maiden Women's World Cup, claiming the final wicket of Nadine de Klerk.

EMMANUAL YOGINI

that to dedicate his time entirely to Deepti's career, opening an academy along the way.

"If I were the first in my family asking to be allowed to do sport, maybe things would have been very different," she reflects on a choice that was neither financially nor culturally popular back then.

Cricket, at first, meant sneaking into her brother's matches or training sessions before she convinced her father to let her go without resorting to clandestine means.

The story of her sitting on the sidelines at the Eklavya Sports Stadium and then throwing a ball about 50 metres to hit the stumps directly, leading to a chance discovery by India international Hemlata Kala, is now a famous one.

What few know is that the now ruthless Deepti once barely looked anyone in the eye.

A 15-year transformation from a diminutive, soft-spoken boy-cut sporting kid into a sought-after all-rounder on the international stage is something former India cricketer and Uttar Pradesh Cricket Association general manager Rita Dey has witnessed up close.

A medium pacer in her early days, Deepti showed a jerk in her bowling action, prompting Rita to push her towards off-spin, and a willing Deepti agreed immediately.

"This has been the case all through her career. She is not one to say no. She will agree and work on anything the team wants her to do. Open the batting, go down to number eight, open the bowling, field in tough positions, she will do it all. She is an incredibly hard-working and obedient girl," Rita recalls.

"She listened to everyone, her coach, me, her brother. And she would take that and think it over. She would then come back with

questions, notes, or follow-ups. She got mature well before she needed to, cricket-wise."

Thirst for redemption

From being desperate to play, Deepti evolved into a triumph-hungry cricketer, with the 2017 World Cup becoming the turning point. Rita was consumed by joy when she saw her protegee named in the squad. Consciously or not, she had pinned an unfulfilled desire of her own onto Deepti.

"I couldn't play the 1997 World Cup as my father passed away right before. Through Deepti, it was a chance to not just be a part of it, but we got so close to winning the cup."

Deepti still remembers sitting in the dugout as that final against England, one the Women in Blue would lose by nine runs, unfolded.

"Everything was going well; we had a decent partnership going and in no time, we lost," she reminisces, looking back at a shocking collapse that sent India spiralling from a position of advantage.

"Losing a match like that, so